

2

AN UNSETTLED MIND

After the defeat at Nimla, Shah Shuja experienced a prolonged period of humiliation and exile. His wanderings were made all the more perilous by the fact that he was carrying on his person the single most valuable jewel in the world.

For several months Shuja visited the durbars of his allies, asking for their help in mounting a campaign to regain his kingdom and depose Shah Mahmoud and the Barakzais. One night, a former courtier named Atta Mohammad invited him to stay at the great fortress of Attock which guards the principal crossing over the Indus. There, according to Mirza ‘Ata,

> they invited Shah Shuja to a private party where they served sweet water melons and started playfully throwing the melon skins at each other. But the jest bit by bit turned to scorn and effrontery, and Shah Shuja soon found himself arrested, held first in Attock then sent under close surveillance to Kashmir where he was kept prisoner in a fort . . . The lancet was frequently held over his eyes; and his keeper once took him into the Indus, with his arms bound, threatening him with instant death if he didn’t hand over the celebrated diamond.[1]

Wa’fa Begum, meanwhile, was loyally working to get him out. After her husband’s defeat she had made her way to Lahore, where according to Sikh sources she independently took it upon herself to negotiate a deal with the Sikh Maharajah, Ranjit Singh, offering him the Koh-i-Nur if he helped release her husband from prison.[2] Ranjit Singh agreed to her terms. In the